GLOBAL MOBILE ASSOCIATION EXECUTIVE WHITE PAPER SERIES

The State of the Global Secondary Mobile Ecosystem

Market Forces, Growth Opportunities, and the Road Ahead

3.2%	$6.4B	82M
Projected 2025 growth in used smartphone shipments	Returned to U.S. consumers through trade-in programs in 2025	Metric tonnes of global e-waste projected by 2030

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Prepared by GMA Research and Insights

ABOUT THIS PUBLICATION

About the Global Mobile Association

The Global Mobile Association exists to serve the global used mobile ecosystem by bringing members together year-round through education, resources, leadership development, advocacy, business support, and meaningful industry connection.

Purpose of the White Paper Series

The GMA Executive White Paper Series translates credible market research into practical insight for the companies and leaders shaping the secondary mobile economy. Each paper is designed to clarify an important issue, identify business implications, and provide actions members can use to strengthen their organizations.

Research Scope

This first edition analyzes public information available through June 2026. It focuses on used and refurbished smartphones, trade-in and resale channels, device longevity, affordability, policy developments, market supply, and the operating conditions that influence secondary mobile businesses. It does not attempt to define grading standards, address IT asset disposition, or represent the broader enterprise mobility market.

Important Notice

This paper is provided for general educational and strategic planning purposes. It is not legal, regulatory, tax, investment, or accounting advice. Market estimates vary by source because definitions, geographic coverage, and channel reporting differ.

How to use this paper

Executives can use the findings to test strategic assumptions, identify growth priorities, strengthen operating discipline, and guide conversations with suppliers, buyers, technology partners, and employees.

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Key Terms Used in This Paper

Term	Working definition
Secondary mobile ecosystem	The commercial network that acquires, processes, redistributes, resells, protects, finances, or enables the continued use of mobile devices.
Used smartphone	A previously owned device resold with or without professional processing.
Refurbished smartphone	A used device that has undergone inspection, testing, repair, cleaning, or restoration before resale.
Recommerce	The organized acquisition and resale of previously owned products through digital or physical channels.
Trade-in	A transaction in which a customer exchanges an existing device for credit, cash, or another benefit.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

A Growth Market Becoming Essential Infrastructure

The secondary mobile ecosystem is moving from a fragmented alternative channel into a more established part of the global technology economy. The shift is being driven by a durable combination of affordability, longer device lifecycles, mainstream trade-in programs, improving consumer acceptance, and the economic value retained in premium smartphones. Public forecasts and market reports point in the same direction even when their definitions differ: used smartphones are growing faster than new devices, and the channel is becoming more strategically important to consumers, carriers, retailers, distributors, recommerce platforms, processors, and technology providers.

IDC projected global used smartphone shipments to grow 3.2% in 2025, compared with 1.0% for new smartphones. Counterpoint Research reported that global refurbished smartphone sales grew 5% in 2024, versus 3% growth in the new-device market. These are not explosive figures, but they signal structural resilience in a mature product category.

3.2x	**IDC projected used smartphone shipment growth to be more than three times the growth rate of new smartphone shipments in 2025.**

The strongest signal may be the behavior of device owners. Assurant reported that U.S. trade-in programs returned a record $6.4 billion to consumers in 2025, up 42% from 2024. The average age of devices at trade-in also reached 3.80 years for iPhones and 3.96 years for Android devices. Longer ownership cycles do not eliminate secondary supply. They change its timing, mix, condition, and value.

Five conclusions for industry leaders

- Demand is broadening beyond purely price-sensitive buyers. Reliability, access to premium models, warranties, and trusted channels are moving used devices closer to the mainstream.
- Supply quality and predictability are becoming more important than total theoretical device availability. Devices held in drawers or delayed in upgrade cycles do not automatically become commercial inventory.
- Trade-in has become a strategic supply engine, but programs must compete for consumer participation and manage older average device ages.
- Policy is increasingly designed to extend device life. European ecodesign, energy labeling, repairability, software-support, and right-to-repair requirements will influence device durability and secondary-market opportunity.
- Profitable growth will favor companies that combine disciplined sourcing, accurate inventory visibility, efficient processing, trusted buyer relationships, and technology-enabled operations.

GMA perspective

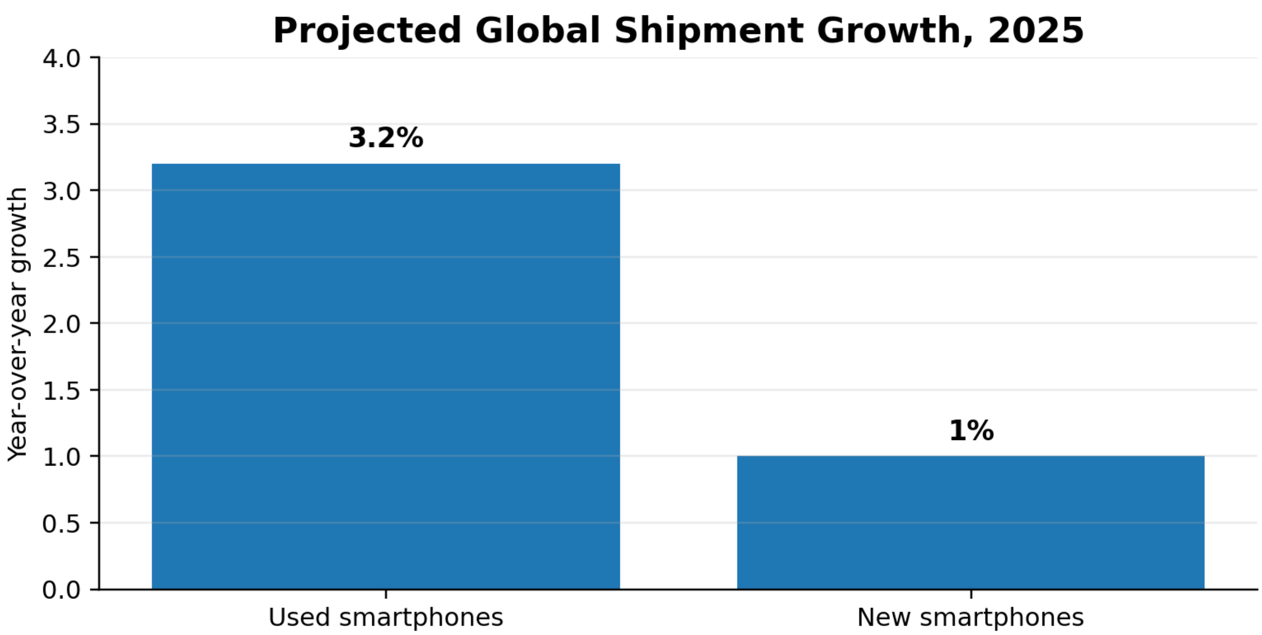
The industry opportunity is no longer simply to sell more used phones. It is to build a stronger, more connected ecosystem capable of turning device longevity, affordability, and retained value into sustainable business growth.

1 | MARKET STRUCTURE

A Market Moving Into the Mainstream

The global smartphone market is large, mature, and deeply embedded in economic and social life. GSMA estimated that mobile technologies and services generated $6.5 trillion of global economic value in 2024, or approximately 5.8% of global GDP. Within that larger economy, the secondary market performs several important functions: it makes capable devices available at lower price points, preserves residual asset value, supports trade-in and upgrade economics, creates additional sales channels, and extends useful device life.

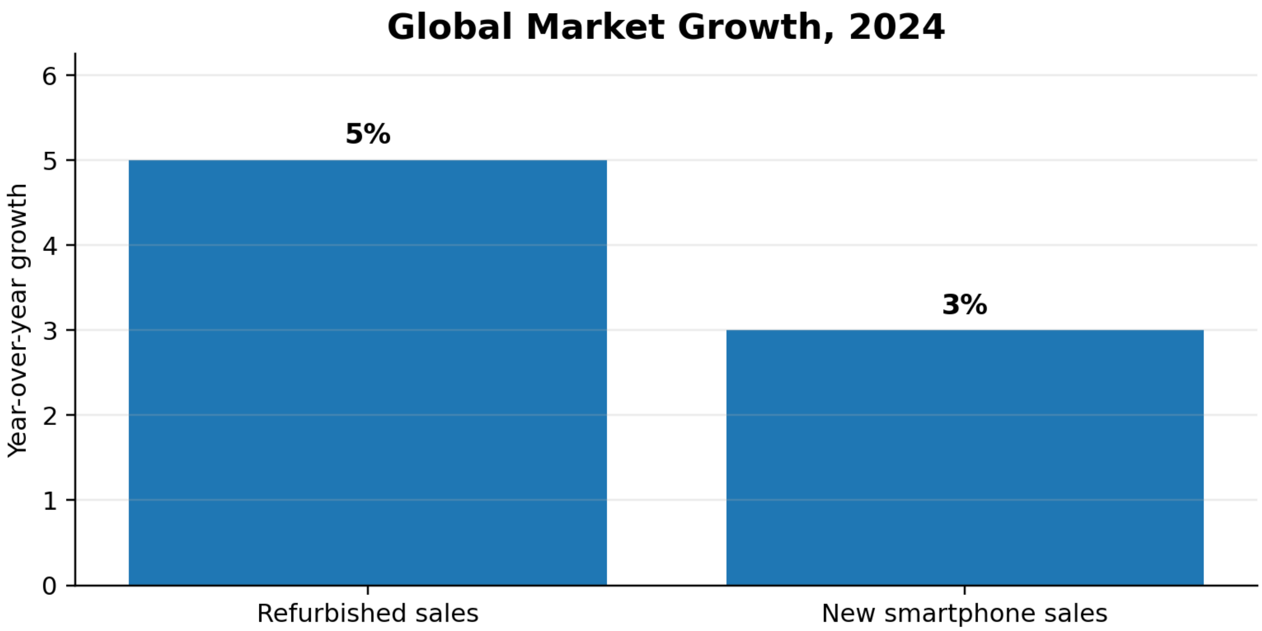
For many years, used devices were treated as a lower-tier alternative to new hardware. That positioning is changing. Premium devices remain technically useful for longer, software support has improved, consumers are more comfortable buying through established recommerce channels, and warranties and return policies are more common. The result is a market defined less by whether a device is new or used and more by value, reliability, access, and fit for purpose.



Source: IDC, 2025 forecast. Growth rates reflect global shipment projections.

Growth is resilient, but not uniform

Counterpoint Research reported 5% year-over-year growth in global refurbished smartphone sales in 2024. The firm also noted that some established regions showed signs of maturity after several years of growth, while supply of newer models remained a challenge. This distinction matters. The market can grow globally while individual countries, channels, or product tire slowly, consolidate, or shift.



Source: Counterpoint Research, global secondary smartphone market analysis for 2024.

Premium devices anchor residual value

The secondary market benefits from the high original value and long useful life of premium smartphones. A device that remains secure, supported, and capable several years after launch can move through multiple owners and markets. This retained utility creates room for trade-in credits, wholesale transactions, recommerce margins, protection products, financing, accessories, and processing services. It also increases the importance of disciplined product knowledge because value is increasingly concentrated by brand, model, storage capacity, market compatibility, and age.

What changes when a market becomes mainstream?

Customers expect clearer product information, reliable fulfillment, professional service, predictable returns, and accountable sellers. Growth creates opportunity, but it also raises the standard of execution.

2 | DEMAND

The Forces Reshaping Demand

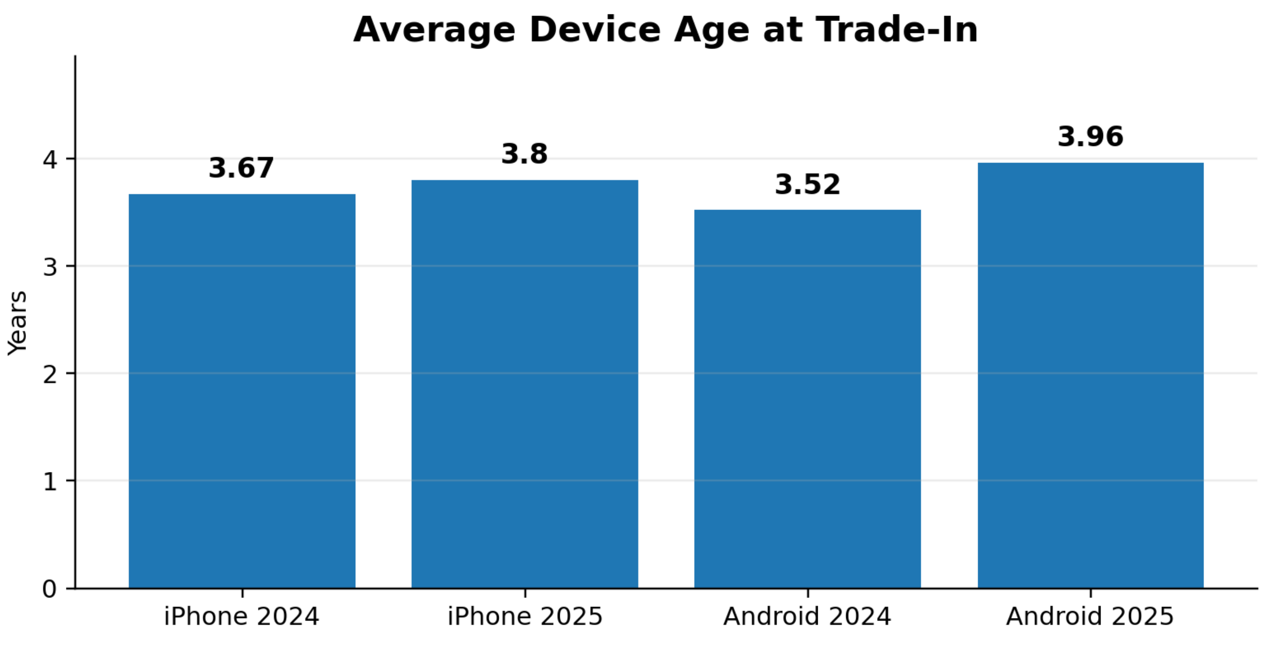
Affordability is becoming a strategic market driver

Smartphone affordability is not only a consumer issue; it is a market-development issue. The World Bank has identified the cost of smartphones as a leading barrier to ownership, and GSMA research continues to identify handset affordability as a major obstacle to mobile internet adoption in low- and middle-income countries. A professionally delivered used device can reduce the entry price for a capable smartphone without requiring the buyer to accept the limitations of the lowest-cost new hardware.

This creates opportunity across mature and emerging markets. In higher-income markets, buyers may use the secondary channel to access premium devices at a lower price. In lower-income markets, used devices may provide the most practical path to digital services, education, communication, financial tools, and commerce. The same device can therefore serve very different value propositions depending on the market.

Longer ownership cycles are changing buyer behavior

Consumers are keeping devices longer before trade-in. Assurant's 2025 data showed average turn-in ages of 3.80 years for iPhones and 3.96 years for Android devices, with Android devices surpassing four years in the fourth quarter. Longer cycles reflect improved hardware durability, slower perceived innovation in some upgrade periods, economic pressure, and greater willingness to retain a device that still performs.

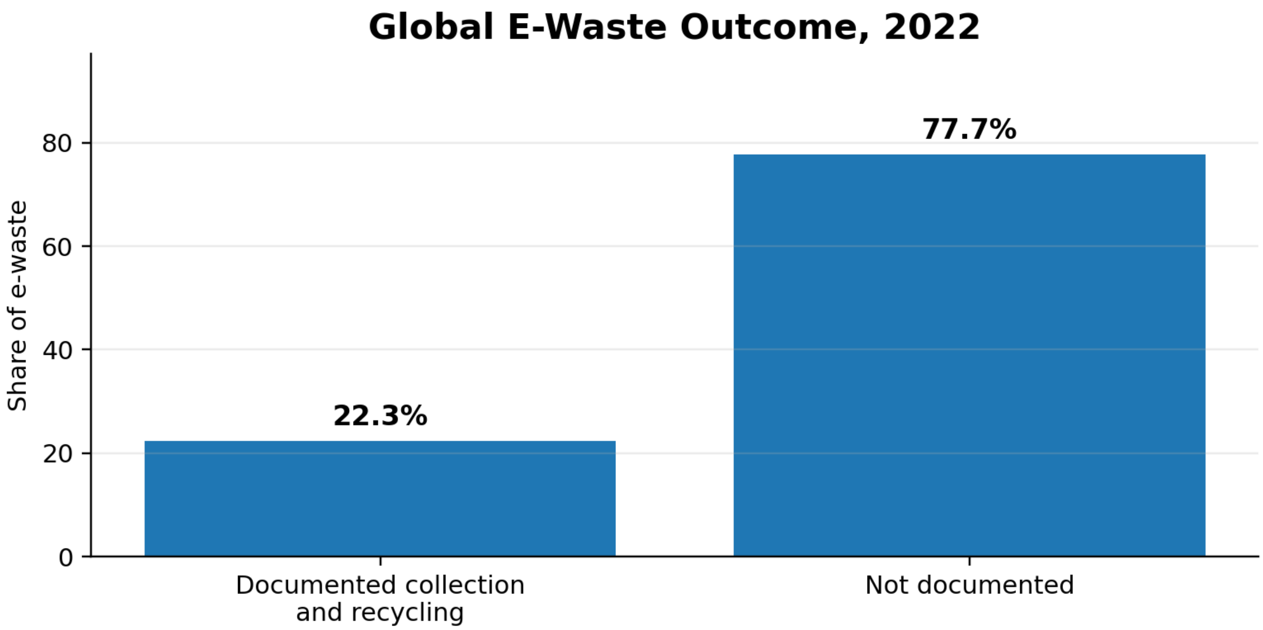


Source: Assurant 2024 and 2025 U.S. trade-in and upgrade trend reports.

For the secondary ecosystem, this trend has two effects. It delays supply and can increase variability in battery condition, cosmetic wear, and repair history. At the same time, it demonstrates that smartphones retain meaningful utility for longer, strengthening the fundamental case for resale and continued use.

Environmental awareness reinforces economic value

Environmental considerations rarely replace price, quality, and convenience as the primary purchase decision, but they increasingly reinforce the secondary-market value proposition. GSMA's circularity work highlights commercial benefits including lower costs, new revenue opportunities, and customer loyalty. The Global E-waste Monitor also shows the scale of the challenge: 62 million tonnes of e-waste were generated in 2022, and only 22.3% was documented as formally collected and recycled.



Source: UNITAR and ITU, The Global E-waste Monitor 2024.

Reuse does not remove the need for responsible end-of-life management, but extending useful life can delay disposal, preserve product value, and improve the economic return on the resources already invested in manufacturing.

3 | SUPPLY

Supply is the Strategic Constraint

Demand receives most of the public attention, but supply determines what the secondary market can actually sell. The theoretical stock of idle smartphones is enormous, yet commercial supply depends on devices being collected, transferred, unlocked, processed, documented, and placed into channels where buyers can use them.

Trade-in is now core infrastructure

Trade-in and upgrade programs create a structured path from first ownership into the secondary market. Assurant reported that U.S. programs returned $6.4 billion to consumers in 2025, a 42% year-over-year increase, with a record $2.2 billion returned in the fourth quarter. Every top-five traded device in 2025 was 5G-enabled, showing that the quality and relevance of secondary supply continues to improve.

$6.4B	**Value returned to U.S. consumers through mobile trade-in programs in 2025, according to Assurant.**

Trade-in programs are not passive collection mechanisms. Their performance depends on customer awareness, simple transactions, competitive offers, convenient fulfillment, fraud controls, accurate valuation, and downstream demand. Operators that depend heavily on trade-in supply should monitor not only unit volume but also model mix, average age, expected recovery, cycle time, and conversion from quoted offer to completed transaction.

The hidden inventory problem

Many devices remain outside organized channels because owners keep them as backups, store them in drawers, give them to family members, or postpone trade-in. The industry therefore competes against inertia. A device that is technically available but never collected has no commercial value to the ecosystem.

The most effective supply strategies will combine multiple sources: carrier and retailer trade-in, direct consumer acquisition, corporate or institutional programs where relevant to the member's business, distributor relationships, marketplaces, insurance replacement flows, and international sourcing. Diversification reduces dependency, but it also increases the need for strong controls, consistent documentation, and clear economics by channel.

Inventory age is a financial issue

Smartphones are depreciating assets. Time affects resale price, compatibility, software support, buyer demand, and working capital. A business can show strong gross margin on paper while destroying cash through slow inventory turns, excessive rework, or inaccurate purchase assumptions. Best-in-class operators manage inventory as a portfolio, not as a pile of units.

Critical operating question

How quickly can the company convert a purchased device into collected cash, after accounting for acquisition cost, processing, freight, returns, warranty exposure, and the cost of capital?

4 | REGIONAL OPPORTUNITY

Regional Opportunity and Market Differences

There is no single global secondary mobile market. Demand, supply, regulation, network compatibility, brand preference, purchasing power, taxes, import rules, financing, and consumer trust vary by country and region. Companies that treat global expansion as a simple extension of domestic sales risk mispricing inventory and underestimating execution complexity.

North America

North America benefits from established trade-in programs, high premium-device penetration, mature carrier and retail channels, and strong demand for recent flagship devices. The opportunity is substantial, but competition is intense. Growth increasingly depends on sourcing advantage, operating efficiency, customer experience, and the ability to convert older devices into the right downstream markets.

Europe

Europe combines established recommerce demand with an increasingly active policy environment. New EU ecodesign and energy-labeling requirements for smartphones and tablets began applying in June 2025. The rules include battery durability, spare-parts availability, longer operating-system support, and a consumer-facing repairability class. The EU right-to-repair directive must be applied by member states from July 2026. These measures are designed to extend product life and make repair and reuse more practical, which may improve future secondary supply while raising compliance expectations.

Asia-Pacific

Asia-Pacific contains major manufacturing centers, large consumer markets, high-growth digital economies, and diverse income levels. Opportunity ranges from premium recommerce in advanced markets to affordability-led demand in emerging markets. Success requires local knowledge of brand preferences, network standards, device registration, import rules, channel structure, and price sensitivity.

Latin America, Middle East, and Africa

These regions offer significant opportunity because smartphones are central to communication, commerce, and financial access, while device affordability remains a barrier for many consumers. The secondary channel can increase access to capable devices, but operators must address logistics, customs, payment risk, warranty expectations, language, and uneven channel maturity.

Region	Primary demand driver	Key operating challenge	Strategic opportunity
North America	Premium value and trade-in	Competition and inventory economics	Recent-model supply and trusted recommerce
Europe	Affordability and circularity	Policy and country variation	Longer device life and structured resale
Asia-Pacific	Scale and diverse demand	Complex market differences	Premium and affordability segments
Latin America / MENA / Africa	Access and affordability	Trade, logistics, and payment risk	Capable smartphones at accessible prices

5 | POLICY AND LIFECYCLE

Regulation, Longevity, and the Changing Device Lifecycle

Public policy is increasingly aligned with longer product life, consumer access to repair, durable batteries, software support, and better product information. This trend is most visible in Europe, but its influence can extend globally because manufacturers, retailers, and supply chains often adapt products and processes across multiple markets.

EU ecodesign and energy labeling

From June 20, 2025, smartphones placed on the EU market became subject to new ecodesign and energy-labeling requirements. The European Commission states that the rules include batteries capable of at least 800 charge cycles while retaining at least 80% of initial capacity, critical spare-parts availability for seven years after a model's sales end, operating-system upgrades for at least five years after the final unit is placed on the market, and access for professional repairers to necessary software or firmware.

For the secondary ecosystem, longer support and more durable hardware can improve the economic life of future device cohorts. However, industry participants should avoid assuming that every device will automatically become easier or more profitable to process. Actual results will depend on part cost, repair economics, software restrictions, security support, and consumer demand.

Right to repair

The EU right-to-repair directive entered into force in July 2024 and must be applied by member states from July 31, 2026. It is designed to encourage longer use of repairable goods and includes manufacturer obligations for covered products, improved access to repair information, and an additional year of legal guarantee when consumers choose repair rather than replacement under the guarantee.

Policy creates both opportunity and responsibility

- Longer software support may extend the commercial life of devices and improve buyer confidence.
- More durable batteries and parts availability may increase the share of devices worth returning to service.
- Consumer-facing information can raise expectations for transparency and documentation across resale channels.
- Cross-border businesses must track differences in product, consumer, tax, customs, and environmental rules.
- Industry leaders should treat compliance as an operating capability, not a last-minute legal review.

Strategic implication

The policy direction favors longer device life. Companies that build capabilities around responsible reuse, clear documentation, efficient processing, and market-specific compliance will be better positioned to capture the value created by that shift.

6 | BUSINESS IMPLICATIONS

Business Implications for Industry Operators

The next stage of secondary-market growth will not reward every participant equally. Market demand may rise while individual businesses struggle with working capital, returns, sourcing quality, buyer concentration, or operating inefficiency. The difference will be execution.

1. Sourcing must become more strategic

Companies should evaluate suppliers and acquisition channels based on total realized value, not headline purchase price. The lowest-priced inventory can become the most expensive after freight, shortages, locks, functional failures, rework, aging, and customer claims.

2. Inventory visibility must improve

Leaders need current visibility into units purchased, received, processed, available, committed, shipped, returned, and aging. Inventory decisions should connect operations, sales, purchasing, and finance rather than being managed in separate systems or spreadsheets.

3. Processing economics should be measured by model and channel

Average margin can hide loss-making combinations. Businesses should understand contribution margin by source, model, processing path, sales channel, customer, and market. This includes labor, parts, freight, transaction fees, warranty, returns, and capital cost.

4. Trust is built through repeatable execution

Trust does not require GMA to recreate technical standards already owned by respected industry bodies. It requires members to communicate clearly, honor commitments, provide accurate documentation, resolve problems, and deliver consistent commercial performance.

5. Technology should solve defined business problems

Automation, diagnostics, pricing intelligence, workflow software, and artificial intelligence can increase speed and accuracy. They create value only when connected to a clear operating problem, reliable data, accountable ownership, and measurable outcomes.

6. Leadership capacity will limit scale

Rapid growth exposes weaknesses in accountability, role clarity, decision-making, communication, and talent development. Companies that invest in capable managers and consistent operating rhythms will be more resilient than those relying on founder intervention for every important decision.

Business priority	Measure to track	Leadership question
Supply	Yield, model mix, realized acquisition cost	Which sources create the strongest total return?
Inventory	Days on hand, aging, turn rate	Where is cash becoming trapped?
Operations	Cycle time, cost per unit, rework	Which process constraint limits throughput?
Sales	Margin by customer and channel	Are we growing profitable relationships?
Risk	Returns, claims, fraud loss, compliance exceptions	Which risks could materially damage trust or cash flow?
People	Productivity, retention, leadership readiness	Do managers have clarity and capability to scale

7 | OUTLOOK

The GMA Strategic Outlook

The secondary mobile ecosystem is positioned for continued relevance because it sits at the intersection of affordability, retained asset value, device longevity, digital access, and commercial opportunity. The market will remain complex. Definitions will vary, supply will be uneven, and regional economics will continue to differ. That complexity is exactly why industry connection and practical education matter.

What GMA expects over the next three years

- Used smartphones will continue to outgrow the new-device market in percentage terms, although growth will vary significantly by region and product tier.
- Trade-in programs will become more important as structured supply channels and as tools for customer retention and upgrade affordability.
- Average device age will remain elevated, increasing the need for disciplined valuation, efficient processing, and channel-specific merchandising.
- Policy supporting durability, software support, repair, and reuse will gradually improve the secondary potential of newer device generations.
- Technology adoption will accelerate in pricing, workflow management, diagnostics, fraud prevention, inventory planning, and customer engagement.
- Consolidation and partnership will increase as companies seek scale, specialized capabilities, reliable supply, and access to new markets.
- Talent and leadership development will become more important as the industry professionalizes and businesses outgrow informal operating models.

The role of an active association

GMA can help members respond to these shifts without duplicating work already performed by respected organizations. Its value is to connect the segments of the used mobile ecosystem throughout the year, translate change into practical business insight, develop leaders, support global market understanding, and create forums where members can learn from one another.

The road ahead

The strongest companies will not be those that simply move the most devices. They will be those that understand where value is created, protect cash, develop capable people, adopt technology with discipline, and build relationships that endure across market cycles.

ACTION FRAMEWORK

Recommended Actions for Industry Leaders

Immediate: next 30 days

- Define the company's exact position in the secondary mobile value chain and the customer problem it solves better than competitors.
- Review inventory aging, realized margins, return rates, and cash conversion by source and sales channel.
- Identify the three external trends most likely to affect supply, demand, or margin over the next 12 months.
- Confirm ownership for compliance, fraud, data handling, and market-entry decisions.
- Engage with GMA committees, webinars, and member conversations aligned to the company's priorities.

Near term: next 90 days

- Build a source-level profitability model that includes acquisition, processing, freight, warranty, returns, and capital cost.
- Create a market and customer concentration review, including dependency on individual suppliers, buyers, brands, and regions.
- Develop a technology roadmap tied to measurable operating problems rather than isolated software purchases.
- Establish a monthly leadership review covering supply, inventory, processing, sales, risk, cash, and talent.
- Identify one partnership or new market opportunity that can be tested with limited capital and clear success measures.

Longer term: next 12 months

- Diversify supply and demand channels without sacrificing control or working-capital discipline.
- Develop stronger management capability and succession depth for critical operating functions.
- Build repeatable market-entry and compliance processes for international growth.
- Use customer, supplier, and operational data to improve forecasting and decision quality.
- Contribute practical insight to the broader ecosystem through GMA research, committees, and peer collaboration.

Join the conversation

GMA members can use this paper as the starting point for committee discussions, executive roundtables, webinars, and future research. The association's role is to help members turn shared market insight into stronger decisions and better business performance.

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METHODOLOGY

Research Methodology and Limitations

This paper is a synthesis of public market research, government and intergovernmental publications, company-reported trade-in data, and GMA analysis. Sources were selected for relevance, credibility, and direct connection to the mobile device lifecycle.

Sources reviewed

- Market forecasts and shipment analyses from IDC and Counterpoint Research.
- Mobile economy, affordability, and circularity research from GSMA.
- Trade-in and device-age data published by Assurant.
- Global e-waste statistics from UNITAR and the International Telecommunication Union.
- Product-longevity and right-to-repair information from the European Commission and European Union institutions.
- Digital inclusion and affordability analysis from the World Bank and OECD.

Important limitations

- The terms used, refurbished, pre-owned, and secondary are not defined consistently across sources.
- Some market datasets are proprietary; this paper relies on publicly available findings rather than full underlying databases.
- Assurant trade-in values cited in this paper describe U.S. programs and should not be treated as a global market total.
- Regional observations are strategic summaries, not country-level legal or commercial guidance.
- Market conditions can change quickly because of economic cycles, tariffs, component costs, regulation, and device-launch timing.

Analytical approach

GMA compared directional findings across sources and focused on themes supported by multiple indicators. Where a conclusion extends beyond a source's explicit statement, it is presented as GMA analysis rather than as a reported fact.

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Citation note

All statistics and regulatory statements in this paper should be read in the context of the cited source. Access dates and source availability may change after publication.

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